

HIS KINGDOM SHRINKS A lion in Gir, which now has a smaller buffer area around it

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who feared their economic freedom would be restricted, following which the government had issued another notification which took the opposite extreme and kept a buffer of only 500 metres. Wildlife activist Biren Padhiya had moved the Gujarat HC in 2017 challenging this, following which both notifications were stayed. In the absence of a notified ESZ, according to Supreme Court guidelines, a buffer of 10 km is considered as a default ESZ. In 2023, the HC allowed the government to notify the ESZ; subsequently, a survey was undertaken and the draft published.

Despite reduction in the area covered, massive protests have broken out across the three districts. Representatives of nearly all 196 villages and politicians across party lines have opposed the ESZ and want its revocation. A local activist associated with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) is leading the protests. "According to the draft notification, 19 everyday activities of villagers that did not require the government's approval earlier will now require it. This eco zone (sic) is a 'loot zone'," he says indignantly. "Earlier, it was the revenue department, now the forest department will control our lives with their corruption," he adds.

The ruling BJP and the forest department are in damage control mode, circulating pamphlets and holding meetings with village heads to explain that farmers' routine lives or even infrastructure development will remain unaffected and that the ESZ would restrict polluting industries, mining, commercial saw-mills, big hydropower projects and so on. But a few local BJP leaders are siding with protesters.

The BJP district presidents of Junagadh and Gir Somnath have written to Gujarat chief minister Bhupendra Patel to exclude villages in their districts from the proposed ESZ. Former Union minister and president of Indian Farmers Fertilisers Cooperative (IFFCO), Dileep Sanghani, an influential Patidar leader in the region, wants the notification to be scrapped. "I want to ask...how many wild animals have been lost in the last two years? But 39 people have lost their lives in that time in Saurashtra due to attacks from wildlife. ESZs hamper development."

Several gram panchayat, municipal council and municipal corporation polls in Junagadh are scheduled in early 2025. Forest officials say the protests are motivated by vested interests with land banks in the region.

Rajkot-based senior wildlife photographer and former member of the Gujarat State Board of Wildlife in India, Bhushan Pandya, seeks to pacify villagers by explaining that the ESZ is actually good in the long run as polluting industries will be kept out. "Without ESZ, man-wildlife conflicts will increase manifold. As of 2018, around 600 protected areas in the country, including three national parks and 20 sanctuaries in Gujarat, are surrounded by ESZs," Pandya wrote in a letter that was widely carried by the local press.

Biologists and big cat experts lament the shrunk ESZ, but their bigger concern is the protests. Y.V. Jhala, former dean of Wildlife Institute of India, feels conservation is not possible without the support of locals—the biggest stakeholders. "Gir was a sterling example of how an endangered wild animal has thrived in a landscape comprising as much protected forest as pastoral land, towns, industrial areas, ports, roads and railway lines." The chaos, he says, is due to a failure to communicate clearly to villagers the permitted and prohibited land uses and activities in the designated ESZ. ■

LOSS FOR LIONS

- **Draft notification of an eco-sensitive zone around Gir has less area than the previous buffer zone**
- **The move has sparked protests across the three districts in the ESZ**
- **Villagers fear loss of economic freedom and development, right to defend against wild animals**